STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

WHAT THE BEST MANAGERS DO

Ten behaviours from Google's research, why the talent to manage is rare, and how a team can rate its own manager.

70% at least, of the variance in engagement between business units is explained by the manager.

GALLUP, 2015

INSIDE

COVER STORY

When Google removed its engineering managers

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Managers are losing engagement faster than their teams

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TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The ten-behaviour card, to fill in with your team

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NO. 01 · ROLE

In this issue

Each issue of Management Review takes one management question and tests it against the best published research. The first takes the most basic: does the manager matter, and if so, what does a good manager do differently?

The answer comes from two very different directions. Google analysed its own data on managers and arrived at ten behaviours. Gallup measured engagement across teams and showed how much of it depends on the manager. Both reach the same conclusion and run into the same problem: an organisation has to select and develop its good managers, because they will not appear on their own.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Does the manager matter?

In 2002 Google removed its engineering managers. Within months it brought them back. Years later it asked its own data whether managers matter.

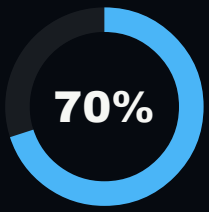
2002
Google removes its engineering managers and brings them back within months.

2011
The New York Times publishes Google's first list: eight behaviours.

2018
Google extends the list to ten behaviours.

Google's people analytics team examined more than 10,000 data points from performance reviews and feedback surveys, along with hundreds of pages of interview notes. The answer was clear: teams with better managers had better results, were happier and left less often.

Gallup reached the same conclusion from another direction, in its 2015 report on managers in the United States.



at least, of the variance in engagement between business units is explained by the manager.

OUR READING

The manager is where an organisation gains or loses most of what its people can do, which makes the role a poor place to look for savings.

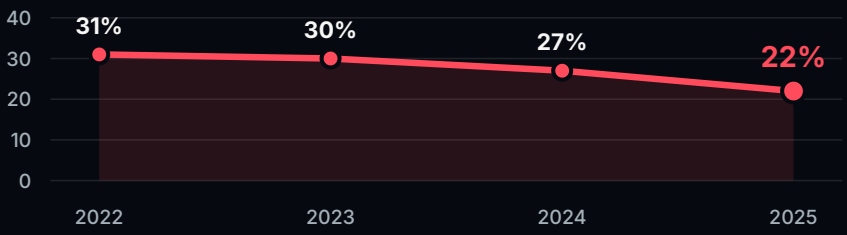
Sources: David A. Garvin, Harvard Business Review, 2013; Adam Bryant, The New York Times, 2011 (via Secondary summaries; the eight behaviours in Garvin, 2013); Google re:Work, 2025; Gallup, 2015

THE NUMBERS

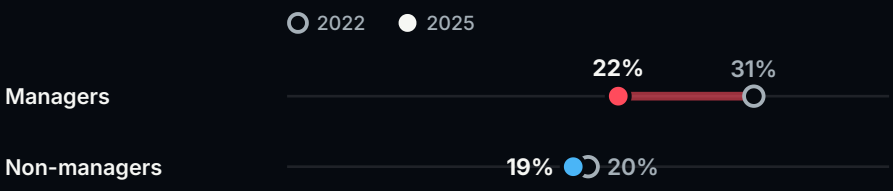
Manager engagement is falling faster

If the manager carries the team, who carries the manager? Managers' engagement has fallen further than that of the people they lead.

ENGAGED MANAGERS WORLDWIDE, 2022–2025



MANAGERS AND NON-MANAGERS, 2022 AND 2025



−9
points for managers, from 2022 to 2025

−1
point for non-managers in the same years

20%
of employees worldwide were engaged in 2025

OUR READING

Managers used to be clearly more engaged than their teams. Today the gap is about 3 points. If most of a team's engagement depends on its manager, this fall does not stay with the manager.

Source: Gallup, 2026

THE MODEL

The ten behaviours of a good manager

Google's list, in its 2018 version. The grouping into three areas is ours, to make the list easier to remember.

People

01 Is a good coach

02 Empowers the team and does not micromanage

03 Creates an inclusive team and cares about people's success and well-being

06 Supports career development and discusses performance

Direction

04 Is productive and results-oriented

07 Has a clear vision and strategy for the team

10 Is a strong decision maker

NEW IN 2018

Connection

05 Communicates well: listens and shares information

08 Has the technical skills to advise the team

09 Collaborates across the company

NEW IN 2018

The last two were added in 2018, after feedback from employees. According to Google, the new list predicts turnover and team satisfaction better than the first one with eight behaviours.

OUR READING

Only one of the ten behaviours concerns technical expertise. The others describe how a manager deals with people, sets direction and cooperates with the rest of the company.

Sources: Google re:Work, 2025; Oliver Staley, Quartz, 2018

More in the essay — Leading people without losing the person

DEVELOPING THE ROLE

Why good managers are rare

If we know what good managers do, why are there so few of them? According to Gallup, the problem starts with the choice.

THE TALENT TO MANAGE, OUT OF 10 PEOPLE



1 in 10
have high talent to manage

2 in 10
have basic talent

7 in 10
the rest

82% of the time, companies do not choose the candidate with the right talent for the manager's job.

THE FIVE TALENTS GALLUP FINDS IN GREAT MANAGERS

01	**Motivates**	Moves every person and ties them to a clear mission.
02	**Drives results**	Sees the work through, against obstacles and resistance.
03	**Creates accountability**	Makes it clear who answers for what.
04	**Builds trust**	Builds relationships on open dialogue and transparency.
05	**Decides on the work**	Decides on the merits of the work, whatever the politics.

OUR READING

Training helps, but it cannot make up for the wrong choice. Before the next promotion in your team, try a different first question: does this person help others work well?

Source: Randall Beck & Jim Harter, Gallup, 2014

HOW IT IS MEASURED

The team rates the manager

Google did not leave the list on a wall. It turned it into a survey that each team fills in about its own manager.

1. **Twice a year**
   The survey is repeated, so the manager can see whether anything is changing.
2. **Anonymous**
   The manager sees only an anonymised, aggregated report.
3. **About behaviour**
   In 2017 there were 13 questions, tied to the behaviours on the list.
4. **For development only**
   The result does not count towards the manager's pay or rating, so that people answer honestly.

GOOGLE MANAGERS' SCORES IN THE TEAM SURVEY



Bock presents this as a result of the programme. It was not a controlled experiment, so we take it as a sign of direction and nothing more.

Sources: Quartz, 2017; Laszlo Bock, 2015 (via World Economic Forum, 2015)

The survey as Google described it in 2017.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The ten-behaviour card

Fill it in yourself, then ask your team to fill it in without names. The work starts where the two versions differ.

1 = rarely · 5 = always		1	2	3	4	5
01	Gives me feedback that helps me improve.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	Lets me decide, without checking every step.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	Cares about me as a person, not only about the work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	Keeps the team on its priorities, even under pressure.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	Shares what they know and listens to us.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
06	Has talked with me about my development in the last six months.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
07	Makes it clear why we do the work we do.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
08	Knows our work well enough to advise us.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
09	Works well with the other departments.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	Makes decisions in time, even hard ones.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

After the card

1. Pick the two behaviours with the biggest gap.
2. Tell the team what you will change and how they will notice it.
3. Fill it in again after six months.

A practice the editors propose, modelled on Google's survey. Never use it to decide anyone's rating or pay.

More in the essay — The Operations Manager I want to be

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Following the data: The research behind great managers
Google re:Work, 2025
https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/following-the-data-the-research-behind-great-managers

How Google Sold Its Engineers on Management
David A. Garvin, Harvard Business Review, 2013
https://hbr.org/2013/12/how-google-sold-its-engineers-on-management

Google's Quest to Build a Better Boss
Adam Bryant, The New York Times, 2011 · via Secondary summaries; the eight behaviours in Garvin, 2013

State of the American Manager
Gallup, 2015
https://www.gallup.com/services/182138/state-american-manager.aspx

State of the Global Workplace 2026
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349484/state-of-the-global-workplace.aspx

Why Great Managers Are So Rare
Randall Beck & Jim Harter, Gallup, 2014
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/231593/why-great-managers-so-rare.aspx

Manager feedback at Google: employees are asked 13 questions about their bosses
Quartz, 2017
https://qz.com/1058760/manager-feedback-at-google-employees-are-asked-13-questions-about-their-bosses-as-part-of-a-semi-annual-review-goog-googl

Google is expanding its list of what it takes to be a great manager
Oliver Staley, Quartz, 2018
https://www.govexec.com/management/2018/02/google-expanding-its-list-what-it-takes-be-great-manager/146312/

Work Rules!
Laszlo Bock, 2015 · via World Economic Forum, 2015
https://www.weforum.org/stories/2015/04/the-9-habits-of-the-best-managers-according-to-googles-hr-boss/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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